Finally, in desperation, Akbar sent an order banning anyone from supplying the prince with drink. This cold turkey regime did no good; in fact, it killed Daniyal. The prince asked his friends to smuggle him wine any way they could: in animal entrails, in gun barrels. It was not alcohol, therefore, that poisoned Daniyal, but rust from the barrel of his favourite musket, improvised into a decanter.

In March 1605, after forty days of agony, Akbar's youngest son died.

The good-looking young man, fond of poetry and hunting, was evidently much loved. The women of his harem were heartbroken and furious at his demise. Daniyal need not have died: he had fathered a son only the previous year, and still managed to keep the fast of Ramzan. He was not so weak, that is, not entirely enslaved to wine as yet. If only his friends had not indulged him. They were all arrested, nine in all, including a gunman, two eunuchs and a barber; and the women had them all killed 'by sticks and stones, clods and kicks'.[21]

According to Inayatullah, when the news reached Akbar, 'there was no upset in his disposition'. Daniyal's harem might scream or weep in grief and anger, but what could Akbar do or feel? God had given him three sons, and now, no matter how Akbar fought to save them, He was taking them away, one by one. Akbar had looked for signs from the divine most of his ruling life; what did he think of God's actions now, His wilful murder of Akbar's heirs?

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It was over forty years since Akbar went on his mad ride on musth Hawai, racing across the Yamuna, pitching and rolling upon a bridge made of boats, offering God His vengeance while Shamsuddin Ataka threw off his turban and Agra's citizens wondered if their emperor had 'some drunken-ness in the brain'.[22]

If Akbar had displeased God, then God would take Akbar's life.

Now, on those very banks of that river, Akbar asked for God's opinion one last time. He arranged an elephant fight – no ordinary entertainment, but a duel tense with undercurrents. The two fighting elephants belonged to Salim and his son Khusro, the grandson Akbar favoured so highly that, at under eighteen, he held a rank of 10,000, a drum and his own standard. It